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From September, 1939, till August, 1942

THE propaganda offensive of the Forward Bloc was in full swing from May, 1939, onwards. In July of that year, the Gandhi Wing reacted by trying to curb this activity. On some pretext or other, "disciplinary action" was taken against some members of the Bloc by the Congress Working Committee. But this only served to strengthen the morale of the Bloc members and to increase their popularity among the masses.

On September 3, 1939, the writer was addressing a mammoth meeting on the sea-beach in Madras where about two hundred thousand people were present—the biggest meeting he has ever addressed—when somebody from the audience put an evening paper into his hand. He looked and read that Britain was at war with Germany. Immediately, the speaker switched over to the subject of the war. The much expected crisis had at last come. This was India's golden opportunity.

On the same day that Britain declared war on Germany, the Viceroy declared India a belligerent and issued an ordinance containing the most stringent powers for the suppression of internal disorder. On September 11th, he announced that the inauguration of the federal constitution under the Act of 1935 was postponed for the duration of the war.

On September 6th, Mahatma Gandhi, after meeting the Viceroy, Lord Linlithgow, issued a press statement saying that in spite of the differences between India and Britain on the question on Indian independence, India should cooperate with Britain in her hour of danger. This statement came as a bomb-shell to the Indian people, who since 1927, had been taught by the Congress leaders to regard the next war as a unique opportunity for winning freedom. Following the above statement of Gandhi, many leaders